bombing of the Indian aircraft, but the warnings about the terrorists' intentions were ignored.

Krishna was given a mandate and a blank cheque to neutralise the pro-Khalistan groups in Canada. 'I was told to do whatever it takes to get access to every bit of information on the plans made by hardcore Sikh leaders in Canada,' he told me.

Within months of his arrival in Canada in 1987, Krishna was running an asset linked to a gurudwara in Vancouver. He successfully harvested and shipped actionable intelligence on the Babbar Khalsa's activities in Canada and their terror plans against India. Just days after the launch of Operation Black Thunder II in Amritsar by top cop K.P.S. Gill on 9 May 1988 to flush out militants from the Golden Temple, Krishna dismantled a Sikh youth wing operating out of North Mississauga. Although the R&AW felt vulnerable in Canada, using its fledgling network of Indian spies against the strong separatist movement, Krishna often bypassed conventional means to gather productive intelligence.

'There was internal criticism about R&AW effectiveness in Canada. I remember an Indian diplomat had remarked during a party at the embassy that the R&AW survives because its reports are not read by the political bosses and they are lucky because no comments are offered. It was a bit humiliating. From that day on I swore to keep a step ahead of our adversaries. That became my priority. I successfully recruited informers in Ottawa and Winnipeg. I developed two assets deep inside Punjabi print media houses in Toronto and charmed a venom-spewing priest in a Vancouver gurud-wara. I thought he might be a trickster, but that is the risk of our trade. He proved to be a great asset. We paid huge sums to keep the operation against